

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Teaching Notes, Part 5: Unit IV, The History of Theology (Lectures 17 to 22)

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These are your notes. Each lecture gives the opening problem, the teaching content, the references, the cross-references to the rest of the course, the illustrations for the board, and a teaching tip with the reading and the reflection prompt.

THE ARC OF UNIT IV

Unit IV answers the fifth of the six goals, how has theology developed through history, and it carries the second precept of Bernard Lonergan, be intelligent. Having attended, in Unit III, to the sources from which theology draws, the student now asks the next honest question: if the faith is one and unchanging, why has it produced so many different theologies across the centuries? The whole unit rests on a single method, and you must teach it on the first day and hold to it for six lectures: do not teach the dates, teach the question. Every age faced a crisis that forced a question, and the theology of that age is its answer to that question. History taught as a list of councils and years is a graveyard that the student forgets by the feast of Christ the King; history taught as a chain of living questions is a conversation he can join.

The unit moves in six steps. Lecture 17 lays down the principle, that each age writes its theology in answer to its own crisis, and that the Gospel does not change while the questions do. Lecture 18 takes up the Patristic age and its great question, who is this Jesus, answered at Nicaea and Chalcedon. Lecture 19 takes up the Scholastic age and its question, whether faith and reason can live together, answered in the synthesis of Thomas Aquinas. Lecture 20 takes up the Reformation and Trent and their question, who saves and how, the question of grace and justification. Lecture 21 takes up the modern age and its harder question, how to believe at all in a world that doubts. Lecture 22 takes up the Second Vatican Council and asks what the Church woke up to, and so it carries the student to the doorstep of the present.

The thread through all six is intelligence in the precise sense Lonergan gave it: having attended to the data, seek the insight, the pattern, the meaning that holds the data together. To be intelligent in history is to ask, of every age, not merely what happened but why, what question was being struggled with, and what truth each answer was guarding. The sin against this unit is the lazy mind that collects facts and never asks what they mean. Keep the precept be intelligent on the board beside the six questions, and at the close of each class ask the students to name the question that the age of the day was trying to answer.

LECTURE 17: Why does every age produce a different theology?

The opening problem. Set a thick history of theology on the desk and let the students imagine turning its pages: Nicaea in 325, Chalcedon in 451, Trent, the First Vatican Council, the Second, a long parade of councils, dates, and hard names, and the eyes glaze over by the third page. Then put the real question to them. If the Gospel is one and does not change, why does each age produce a theology of its own? Three uneasy answers lie behind the question, and most students hold one of them. Either the truth itself keeps changing, which frightens the believer; or the older theologies were simply wrong and we have finally got it right, which is the chronological snobbery of Lecture 13; or the whole thing is a museum of dead quarrels with nothing to say to a parish priest. Hold the unease, and then turn it. The Gospel does not change. The questions change. Each age writes its theology in answer to its own crisis, and to study that history well is to ask, of every age, not "in what year" but "to what question."

The teaching content. Begin from the principle the students already met in Lecture 13, the development of the one faith. The deposit of faith does not change, and yet the understanding of it truly grows, for there is a growth in insight into the realities and the words that have been handed on (*Dei Verbum* 8), and John Henry Newman taught that authentic development unfolds the same faith the way the oak unfolds the acorn, the same thing grown and never a different thing (*An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine*). So theology has a history not because the truth is unstable but because the Church is alive. A living body receives the one faith in every generation and must restate it freshly for its own hour, against its own errors, in its own tongue. A theology that never changed its expression would be the sign not of a faith kept pure but of a faith gone dead.

Now give the students the method that orders the whole unit, and make them write it down: teach the question, not the date. Then set before them the one map of the ages, in a single view, so that the six lectures have a shape before they begin. The Patristic age asked, who is Jesus, and answered at Nicaea and Chalcedon, against the heresies that tore at the person of Christ. The Scholastic age asked whether faith and reason can live together, when the lost reason of Aristotle came flooding back into the schools, and answered in the great synthesis of Aquinas. The Reformation and the Council of Trent asked who saves and how, the question of grace, when a terrified monk found peace in the mercy of God. The modern age asked the hardest question of all, not which God but whether there is a God to believe in, when reason and science and suspicion pressed faith to the margins. And the Second Vatican Council asked how the Church must read the signs of its own time, and woke from a long defensive sleep. Five ages, five crises, five questions, one Gospel.

Press home why this matters for a man who will spend his life in a parish in Bengal, and not in a library. He too lives in an age that has its own question. The signs of his own time, the many faiths pressing on every side, the weight of poverty and caste, the secular doubt of the young, the new digital world, pose questions that the Fathers never faced and could not have imagined. To learn how every past age met its own question, faithfully and freshly, is to be trained to meet his own. This unit, then, is not antiquarianism; it is an apprenticeship.

The student watches five master generations at work on the one Gospel, so that he may take up the same tools for the questions of his own day.

Close by warning against the two errors that this unit must steer between, for they are the same two errors that Lecture 13 named about Tradition. The first is to treat all change as betrayal, the error of the man who decides that the only true theology is that of one favoured age, and who judges every later development a fall. The second is to treat all change as progress, the chronological snobbery of the man who assumes that the newest theology is the truest simply because it is the newest. The test of true development, as Newman taught, is not novelty and not mere antiquity but continuity of identity: does the new expression carry forward the same faith, or does it contradict it? Where it carries the faith forward, it is growth; where it contradicts the faith, it is the corruption of Lecture 10. The student who holds this test in his hand can walk through the whole history of theology without fear and without naivety. This is the precept be intelligent at work: not to collect the dates but to seek the pattern, and to ask of every age what question it was answering and what truth it was guarding.

Illustration. The first image is the tailor and the one bolt of cloth. A master tailor in the bazaar keeps one bolt of fine cloth, the best he has, and from that one cloth he cuts garments for everyone who comes to his shop: a small coat for a child, a long kurta for a tall man, a wide shawl for an old grandmother. The garments are all different, because the bodies are all different, and yet the cloth is one. The Gospel is the one fine cloth, and theology is the cutting of it to clothe each age in its own shape. To complain that the theology of the Fathers does not fit the modern world is like complaining that the grandmother shawl does not fit the child; the cloth is right, but each age must have it cut to its own measure. And a tailor who owned only one finished garment, and tried to force every customer into it, would soon have an empty shop and a naked town.

The second image is the old bridge repaired across the generations. A great stone bridge carries one road across one river, and it has stood for many centuries; but each generation of masons must repair it against the damage of its own time, the flood that scoured the eastern pier, the cart that cracked the parapet, the slow crumbling of the old mortar. One generation works in stone, the next in brick, the latest in iron and concrete, and so the bridge looks a little different in every age; yet it is one bridge, carrying one road, across one river. The faith is that bridge, and the theology of each age is the repair it makes against the damage of its own hour, the heresy that scoured the doctrine of Christ, the doubt that cracked the pier of reason, the despair that crumbled the mortar of hope. The bridge is not rebuilt new in every age; it is kept, by labour fitted to the threat of the time, so that the one road may still cross the one river.

References. The Manual, pages 5 to 8, for the periodisation of the history of theology. *Dei Verbum* 8, for the growth of the understanding of the one faith under the Holy Spirit. John Henry Newman, *An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine* (1845), for development that preserves identity. Gaudium et Spes 4, for the duty of reading the signs of the times in the light of the Gospel. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, Chapter 3, for the contrast between the older theology and the contemporary.

Cross-references. The development of the one faith, and the test of continuity, reach back to Lecture 13, on Tradition, and to the corruption named in Lecture 10. The two errors, the fear of all change and the worship of all change, are the chronological snobbery and the traditionalism of Lecture 13. The signs of the times return in Lecture 21, in Lecture 22, and through the whole of Unit VI, where the student is asked to read the signs of his own age. Each of the five lectures that follow, Lectures 18 to 22, is one age answering one question, and they are the body of which this lecture is the head. The precept be intelligent governs the unit from here.

For the professor. Do not drown the students in dates; give them instead the one map and the one method, and ask them at the end to repeat the method back to you in a single line, teach the question and not the date. The danger of this lecture is that it becomes a dry timetable; the cure is to make it personal at once, by telling them that they too live in an age with a question, and that this whole unit is their training for the day they must answer it in a Bengal parish. Reading: the Manual, pages 5 to 8. Reflection prompt: "The one great question I think my own age is asking about God is..."

LECTURE 18: Who is this Jesus? (The Patristic age)

The opening problem. Put the question and let it sit in the room, for it is the question on which everything else hangs. The first Christians were Jews, who confessed with their whole hearts that God is one; and yet they prayed to Jesus, worshipped him, baptised in his name, and called him Lord. So a question pressed upon them with terrible force, and it would not let them rest: who exactly is this Jesus? A great prophet, like Moses or Elijah? An angel, a high spirit sent from heaven? A god come down in human disguise, as the old stories told of the gods? Or God himself, truly God? Everything hangs on the answer. If he is only a creature, however exalted, then in worshipping him we are idolaters, and worse, a creature cannot save us, for only God can save. If he is truly God, then how do we still say that God is one? The whole Patristic age is the Church wrestling this one question to the ground, and the wrestling cost three centuries, four great councils, exiles, and blood. This is not an abstract puzzle for scholars; it is the question of whom we adore on our knees.

The teaching content. The Fathers and where their theology was born. The Fathers, the *patres*, are the great teachers of the first Christian centuries, from the apostolic fathers such as Ignatius of Antioch and Clement of Rome, through the apologists such as Justin Martyr, to Irenaeus of Lyons, who defended the rule of faith against the Gnostics, the brilliant Alexandrians Clement and Origen, the towering figures of the fourth century, and the great Latins Augustine, Ambrose, Jerome, and Leo. Remember from Lecture 7 that their theology was the contemplative and doxological theology, born not first in the lecture hall but in prayer, in preaching, in the liturgy, and in the defence of the faith against heresy. They did their thinking on their knees and in the heat of controversy, and the doctrine they hammered out is the doctrine the parish still confesses every Sunday.

The question comes to a head: is the Son truly God? Early in the fourth century, in Alexandria, a priest named Arius gave a clear and dangerous answer, meaning well. To

protect the oneness and the transcendence of the one God, Arius taught that the Son is the first and highest of all creatures, made by the Father out of nothing, so that, in his famous slogan, there was a time when the Son was not. The Son, for Arius, is not truly God but a creature, however exalted above all others. See at once the deadly stakes, which are not about a Greek word but about salvation: if the Son is a creature, then the Church worships a creature, which is idolatry; and a creature cannot bridge the gulf between God and man, so a creature Christ cannot save. This error is called Arianism, and you will hear it again at every door in Bengal where a sect teaches that Jesus was only a holy man.

Nicaea answers, in 325. The Emperor Constantine called the first ecumenical council, at Nicaea, and the Church answered Arius. She confessed that the Son is *homoousios* with the Father, of one substance, one being, with the Father: God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten and not made, of one substance with the Father. This is the heart of the Nicene Creed, and it is your reading for the day. The word *homoousios* drew the line: the Son is not a higher creature but is, with the Father, the one God. The battle did not end at Nicaea; for fifty years the Arian reaction held much of the Church, and Athanasius of Alexandria defended the council almost alone, so that the tradition remembers Athanasius against the world. He gave the reason the whole struggle mattered in one line: the Son of God became what we are so that we might become what he is (*On the Incarnation*). Only God could do that.

The Cappadocians and the Spirit, and Constantinople in 381. Later in the fourth century the three Cappadocian Fathers, Basil the Great, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Gregory of Nyssa, completed the grammar of the Trinity: one *ousia*, one being, in three *hypostaseis*, three persons, so that we confess one God in three, neither three gods nor one God wearing three masks. They also defended the divinity of the Holy Spirit against those who would make the Spirit a creature, and the First Council of Constantinople, in 381, confirmed the full divinity of the Spirit and gave the Creed the final shape that the Church still sings at Mass.

The question shifts: how is the one Christ both God and man? Once the Son was confessed as truly God, a second and subtler question opened. If Jesus is truly God and truly man, how do the two go together in one Christ? Here too well-meant errors seized one truth and lost the rest, exactly as Lecture 10 said every heresy does. Apollinarius so stressed the divinity that he denied Christ a full human mind, as though the Word simply replaced the human soul; and Gregory of Nazianzus answered with the principle that guards our salvation, that what is not assumed is not healed, so that Christ had to take a whole humanity, mind and will and all, in order to save the whole human person. Two great schools then pulled in opposite directions, each guarding a real truth. The school of Alexandria stressed the unity of Christ, the one divine subject, the Word made flesh, and its champion was Cyril of Alexandria. The school of Antioch stressed the distinction of the two natures and the full reality of the humanity. Each school was right in what it affirmed and dangerous in what it forgot.

Ephesus in 431 and Chalcedon in 451. Nestorius, of the Antiochene school, so divided the natures that he seemed to make two sons, two persons, in Christ, and he refused to call

Mary *Theotokos*, the God-bearer, preferring only Christ-bearer. The Council of Ephesus, in 431, answered him and confessed Mary as *Theotokos*, which is first of all not a title about Mary but a confession about her Son: she bears God because the one she bore is God. Then Eutyches, pushing the Alexandrian stress too far, taught that after the union there was only one nature, the humanity swallowed up in the divinity, an error called Monophysitism. The Council of Chalcedon, in 451, gave the great and lasting answer, helped by the Tome of Pope Leo: one and the same Christ, one person in two natures, truly God and truly man, made known in two natures without confusion, without change, without division, and without separation. Those four words are the banks of the river for all Christology ever after: the natures are not blended into a third thing, and they are not split into two Christs; they are united, whole and distinct, in the one Lord.

The pattern, and the payoff for Bengal. Hold up the pattern, for it is the precept be intelligent in action. The student should not memorise Nicaea 325 and Chalcedon 451 as bare dates, but should understand the one question, who is Jesus, the wrong answers, each a single truth torn from the whole, and the right answer, the councils holding the whole together. And tell him why it still burns. The people of Bengal still ask who Jesus is, in a land of many gods and many avatars, where it is the easiest thing in the world to make Jesus one more avatar among the ten, or one more guru on a long shelf of gurus. The priest who has walked through the Patristic struggle can preach a Jesus who is neither a demigod nor a mere teacher of wisdom, but the one Lord, truly God and truly man, the only Saviour, and he can love the title *Theotokos* in the devotion of his people as the patristic guard upon the divinity of Christ.

Illustration. The first image is the iron in the fire, which the Fathers themselves loved. Take a bar of iron and thrust it into a hot furnace, and after a while you draw out a bar that glows red, that gives heat and light. It is fully iron still, and it is fully filled with fire; you cannot scrape the heat off the iron, for the two are united through and through; and yet the iron has not stopped being iron, nor has the fire stopped being fire. There you have Chalcedon on the board: the one Christ is fully God and fully man, the two natures united without confusion and without separation, like the fire and the iron in one glowing bar. Arius said the bar was only cold iron, no fire in it at all. Eutyches said the fire had burned the iron away. The Church says: behold the iron, glowing with fire, one bar, and worship.

The second image is the portrait of the one King, painted by several painters. A great king sat for his portrait, and several painters were set to the task. The first painted only the crown and the throne and the blaze of majesty, and forgot to paint the man, so that his picture was a glory with no human face. The second painted only the tired man, the lines around the eyes, the weary hand, and forgot the crown, so that his picture was a labourer no one would call a king. A third painted two separate sitters on one canvas, a king on the left and a man on the right, as though they were two persons sharing a frame. And the true portrait showed the one King, crowned and human at once, one face, both majesty and weariness in the single man. Arius painted a servant with no crown; Eutyches painted a crown that had burned away the man; Nestorius painted two sitters on one canvas; and Chalcedon painted the one King, truly crowned and truly human, the single Lord whom we adore.

References. The Manual, pages 5 to 7, for the Patristic age. The Nicene Creed, that is, the Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed of 325 and 381, for *homoousios* and for the divinity of the Son and the Spirit. The Council of Nicaea (325), the First Council of Constantinople (381), the Council of Ephesus (431), and the Council of Chalcedon (451), for the answers of the Church to Arius, to the deniers of the Spirit, to Nestorius, and to Eutyches. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation*, for the Word made man so that man might be made divine. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Letter 101* to Cledonius, for the principle that what is not assumed is not healed. Cyril of Alexandria and the Tome of Pope Leo, for the Christology that fed Chalcedon. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies*, for the early rule of faith against the Gnostics.

Cross-references. The inner shape of heresy, the seizing of one part against the whole, was taught in Lecture 10, where the councils of Nicaea, Constantinople, Ephesus, and Chalcedon were first named and promised to this lecture. The contemplative and doxological theology of the Fathers comes from Lecture 7, and returns in Lecture 29, on Orthodox theology, theology on the knees. The two schools, Alexandrian and Antiochene, are an example of the legitimate plurality with banks of Lecture 11. The Trinity as the centre of all that is revealed comes from Lecture 3. The confession of the divinity of the Spirit grounds the work of the Spirit in Tradition, Lecture 13, and in synodality, Lecture 31. The question whether Jesus is one avatar among many returns in interreligious dialogue, Lecture 33. The library hunt for three Orthodox theologians and for the earliest councils pays off here.

For the professor. The peril of this lecture is that it turns into a parade of dates and Greek words, and the students go to sleep standing up. The cure is to keep returning, after every council, to the one question, who is Jesus, and to the one stake, whom do we worship. Read the Creed aloud and let them realise, perhaps for the first time, that every Sunday in every parish the people recite, without knowing it, the answer the Fathers paid for in exile and blood. Two small matters of accuracy: the manual prints the heresy of Arius as if it had to do with race; it does not, and you will write Arianism correctly on the board, and likewise Irenaeus and the Peshitta, wherever the manual has slipped. Reading: the Manual, pages 5 to 7; the Nicene Creed, with a short word on the Arian struggle. Reflection prompt: "If a Hindu friend asked me how Jesus is more than one avatar among many, I would now begin by saying..."

LECTURE 19: Can faith and reason live together? (The Scholastic age)

The opening problem. For a thousand years in the Latin West, faith had reigned almost unchallenged, and reason had been content to serve as her quiet handmaid in the monasteries. Then, in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, a flood broke in. The lost works of Aristotle, the whole vast system of his reasoning, long preserved and developed by Arab and Jewish scholars such as Avicenna, Averroes, and Maimonides, came pouring back into the universities of Europe, and here was a complete and powerful account of the world, of nature, of the soul, of God, built by pure human reason, with no Bible in sight. The crisis was sharp. Does this new and confident reason threaten the faith? Two frightened answers

offered themselves at once. Some said, ban Aristotle, shut him out, fence off the faith from this dangerous reason, which is the fideism of Lecture 2. Others, the so-called Latin Averroists, let reason swallow faith and spoke of a double truth, as though something could be true in philosophy and false in theology at the same time. So the question of the age stood up in the lecture halls of Paris: can faith and reason live together under one roof, or must the one drive out the other? This is the question of Lecture 2, faith seeking understanding, now grown to the size of a whole age.

The teaching content. The new schools and the new method. The setting is the birth of the universities, at Paris, Oxford, Bologna, in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, where theology became a science taught in the schools, the scholastic sense of theology from Lecture 7. The schoolmen developed a sharp instrument, the *quaestio*, the disputed question, in which a problem is stated, the strongest objections are lined up, the contrary authorities are heard, and a reasoned answer is given that meets every objection. The great *Summa* of Aquinas is built entirely of such questions, thousands of them, and that habit of facing the strongest objection before answering is itself a school of honesty that your students should learn.

Anselm, the bridge. Anselm of Canterbury, in the eleventh century, stands at the doorway between the monastery and the school, and he gave the age its motto, which the students already carry from Lecture 2: *fides quaerens intellectum*, faith seeking understanding, for I believe in order that I may understand, and not the reverse. His famous argument for God in the *Proslogion* is faith reasoning hard, and it is set, do not forget, inside a prayer. Faith comes first, the door; and once inside, faith reaches out to understand the One it has already embraced.

Thomas Aquinas, the great synthesis. Then comes the towering figure of the age, Thomas Aquinas, the Dominican friar, and his achievement is one of the boldest in the history of theology: he did not ban Aristotle and he did not surrender to him; he baptised him. He took the pagan philosopher and set his reason to work in the service of the faith, philosophy as the handmaid of theology from Lecture 11. The principle that governs his whole work is one line you should write on the board and unpack slowly: grace does not destroy nature but perfects it, *gratia non tollit naturam sed perficit*. From this flows his calm confidence that faith and reason can never truly contradict one another, because both come from the one God who is Truth itself; and so, when they seem to clash, either the reasoning is faulty or the theology has been misunderstood, and the honest worker must look again. Aquinas drew a careful line between what reason can reach on its own, the existence of God, the moral law, the soul, which he called the preambles of faith, and what only revelation can give, the Trinity, the Incarnation, grace, which he called the mysteries of faith. His Five Ways are reason climbing toward God from the world he has made (*Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 2). And his *Summa Theologiae* stands as the great cathedral of the medieval synthesis, in which faith and reason are not rivals but partners building one house.

Bonaventure, and the breadth of the synthesis. Beside Aquinas stands Bonaventure, the Franciscan, who built the synthesis with a different stress: for him the road of the mind to God, the *Itinerarium*, is more affective and more mystical, all knowing meant to end in

loving, reason in the service of contemplation. Hold up Aquinas and Bonaventure together as a fine example of the legitimate plurality of Lecture 11, the Dominican way of the intellect and the Franciscan way of the heart, both faithful, both needed, one faith thought in two keys.

Scotus, Ockham, and the loosening. Then, in the later medieval period, the synthesis began to come apart, and the student should see this, because it sets up the modern crisis of the next lecture. Duns Scotus, the subtle doctor, and above all William of Ockham, with his nominalism and his famous razor, began to drive a wedge between faith and reason. Ockham held that many truths of the faith cannot be reached or supported by reason at all, but are held by authority alone. The motive was pious, to guard the freedom of God and the purity of faith, but the effect was grave: faith and reason, such close partners in Aquinas, began to keep separate rooms, and the long divorce had begun. The age that achieved the great marriage also planted the seed of its undoing.

Fides et Ratio and the payoff. Your reading, *Fides et Ratio*, sections 43 to 48, is John Paul II telling this very history: the harmony of faith and reason brought to its height in Aquinas, held up as the enduring model, and then the slow separation that would leave the modern world with a reason cut off from faith and a faith suspected by reason. The two wings of Lecture 4 and Lecture 11 flew together in the thirteenth century and began to come apart in the late medieval schools. And here is the payoff for the seminarian: he is the heir of Aquinas, and he need not choose between a thinking faith and a believing reason. In an India where some treat religion as pure feeling that fears the laboratory, and treat science as pure fact that has no room for God, the priest can stand as a witness that faith and reason are the two wings of one bird, that the God of the Bible is also the God of every truth the scientist finds, and that to love God with the whole mind is itself a commandment.

Illustration. The first image is the cathedral built by the architect and the master mason. A great cathedral, such as the schoolmen of that very age were raising across Europe, needs two kinds of men working as one. The architect holds the vision of the whole, the soaring shape, the meaning of the building as a house of God; this is faith, which sees the end and the purpose. The master mason holds the calculation of stress and arch and buttress, the hard reckoning of weight and stone that keeps the vision from falling down; this is reason. Build on vision with no engineering, and the beautiful idea collapses in a heap of stone; build on engineering with no vision, and you have a sturdy warehouse, not a house of God. The cathedral stands, and soars, only because the architect and the mason work as one, and the *Summa* of Aquinas is exactly such a cathedral, raised by faith and reason together. The fideist would send the mason home and watch the dream fall; the rationalist would send the architect home and build a shed.

The second image is the keystone of the arch. In a stone arch, two leaning halves would each fall to the ground if they stood alone; what holds them up is the single wedge-shaped stone at the very top, the keystone, that locks the two sides into one and turns two falling halves into one strong span that can bear the weight of a tower. Faith and reason are the two leaning halves; Aquinas set the keystone, the truth that both come from the one God and cannot finally contradict, and so the arch stood and bore great weight. What Ockham began

to do, with the best of intentions, was to loosen that keystone; and when at last it slipped, in the centuries that followed, the arch fell into two broken halves, a faith with no reason on one side and a reason with no faith on the other, which is the rubble the modern age inherited.

References. The Manual, page 7, for the Scholastic age. John Paul II, *Fides et Ratio* (1998), sections 43 to 48, for the medieval synthesis, the model of Aquinas, and the later separation of faith and reason. Anselm of Canterbury, *Proslogion*, for *fides quaerens intellectum* (cross-reference Lecture 2). Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 1, for theology as a science, q. 2 for the Five Ways, and Ia q. 1, a. 8, for grace perfecting nature and reason in the service of faith. Bonaventure, *Itinerarium Mentis in Deum*, for the affective Franciscan road to God. For the recovery of Aristotle through the Arab and Jewish philosophers, Avicenna, Averroes, and Maimonides. William of Ockham and the nominalist separation of faith and reason.

Cross-references. Faith seeking understanding comes from Lecture 2, and the two wings from Lecture 4 and Lecture 11. Philosophy as the handmaid of theology, and the baptising of a pagan reason, come from Lecture 11, and look forward to Lecture 27, where Indian theology thinks with the *darshanas* as the Fathers thought with the Greeks and the medievals with Aristotle. Theology as a science comes from Lecture 9. The plurality of the Dominican and Franciscan ways is the legitimate plurality of Lecture 11. The loosening of the synthesis in late nominalism prepares the modern crisis of Lecture 21, the doubt of a world in which faith and reason have come apart. The precept be intelligent asks the student to grasp why the age asked its question, the flood of Aristotle, and why the answer mattered.

For the professor. Everyone has heard the name of Aquinas, so the danger here is that the students think they already know this age. Make them feel the drama instead: a complete pagan system of reason floods into the Church, which could have panicked and banned it, and instead a Dominican friar sat down and baptised it. Stress that the synthesis was a hard-won achievement and not a thing to be taken for granted, and that its quiet unravelling in the late schools is what set the table for the modern doubt of the next lecture. Send them away seeing that they are heirs of a thinking faith, and need never be ashamed before either the pious or the clever. Reading: the Manual, page 7; *Fides et Ratio*, sections 43 to 48. Reflection prompt: "A place where I have felt faith and reason pulling apart in myself, and how I might begin to hold them together, is..."

LECTURE 20: Who saves, and how? (The Reformation and Trent)

The opening problem. Begin with a man, not a doctrine, for the doctrine was born in his anguish. A young German monk named Martin Luther is terrified of damnation. He fasts, he prays, he confesses for hours, he punishes his body, and still he cannot find peace, because he is sure that a holy God must condemn a sinner like him, and no amount of his own effort feels like enough. Then, reading the Letter to the Romans, he is struck by a sentence that changes his life and then changes Europe: the righteous shall live by faith. He

comes to see that we are made right with God not by piling up our own works and merits to buy his favour, but as a free gift, by grace, received in faith. The discovery sets his heart on fire, and the fire sets a continent ablaze. Pose the question of the age plainly, and pose it without the old venom, for the manual you use is harsh here and forgets its own ecumenical mark: this was a real and agonised question about the very heart of the Gospel. Who saves, and how? Is salvation the free gift of God, received by faith, or is it something we must earn? And who has the authority to say, the Bible alone, or the Church?

The teaching content. The crisis. By the late Middle Ages, the religion of many ordinary Christians had drifted toward an anxious bookkeeping of merits, in which one tried to store up enough good works, prayers, and indulgences to tip the scales at the judgement; and the selling of indulgences, by men such as Tetzel, turned this anxiety into a marketplace. There were real abuses, and there was a real and holy hunger for the assurance of God's mercy. Into this hunger stepped Luther, in 1517, with his Ninety-Five Theses, and after him Calvin, Zwingli, and the other reformers.

The truths the Reformers fought to protect. State the great Reformation slogans fairly, for each one guards a truth the Catholic Church also holds. *Sola gratia*, by grace alone: salvation is the free gift of God and not our own achievement, the very truth Augustine defended against Pelagius in Lecture 10. *Sola fide*, by faith alone: we are justified by faith, and not by works that would put God in our debt. *Sola scriptura*, by Scripture alone, which the students met and answered in Lecture 12. Behind all of them lies *solus Christus*, Christ alone, and *solī Deo gloria*, glory to God alone. The first reformers were not inventing a new religion; they were crying out to protect the freeness of grace and the assurance of the Gospel against a religion that had begun to feel like a wage to be earned.

The knot: justification. The hard theological knot was the doctrine of justification, how a sinner is made right with God. Luther taught that the Christian is *simul iustus et peccator*, at once righteous and a sinner, declared righteous by a righteousness that is Christ's own, credited to us and received by faith alone, with good works following as the fruit but never as the cause. The Catholic concern was twofold: does this make justification only a legal declaration, a verdict spoken over a man who stays inwardly unchanged, and does faith alone cut the nerve of love and of good works, when the Letter of James says plainly that faith apart from works is dead (James 2:26)?

The answer of Trent. The Council of Trent, sitting from 1545 to 1563, gave the considered Catholic answer, above all in its Decree on Justification of 1547, one of the most carefully argued documents of the whole age. Trent taught that justification is not a mere legal declaration laid over an unchanged sinner, but a true making-righteous, in which God by his grace really renews the inmost person and pours his love into the heart. It is by grace, against every trace of Pelagius, and it is received through faith; but the faith that justifies is a faith that works through love (Galatians 5:6), so that the justified truly cooperate with the grace given them, truly grow in holiness, and truly perform good works that, by the gift of God and not by any claim of their own, merit an increase of grace and eternal life. Trent held together what the quarrel had torn apart: grace and human cooperation, faith and love and works, against both the works-righteousness of Pelagius and a misread faith-alone that

would leave the sinner unchanged. And Trent did more than answer; it reformed. It ended the worst abuses, it gave the Church a catechism and a renewed liturgy, and, in a decree that touches these very students, it commanded that every diocese establish a seminary for the proper formation of its priests. The house in which your students sit exists because of this council.

The wound being healed. Teach the ecumenical mark of Lecture 10 here in living colour, and do not repeat the old venom of the manual. In 1999 the Lutheran World Federation and the Catholic Church signed the *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification*, in which Lutherans and Catholics declared a shared understanding of justification by grace through faith, deep enough that the mutual condemnations of the sixteenth century no longer strike the partners as they now teach the faith. The question that split the Western Church five hundred years ago has, in its heart, begun to be healed in our own lifetime. That is the ecumenical mark at work, and it is news the students should carry to a Bengal where Catholic and Protestant Christians often still eye one another with suspicion.

The deeper lesson, and the payoff. Show the students that, as in every controversy, both sides were guarding a truth. The Reformers guarded the freeness of grace and the assurance of the Gospel; Trent guarded the reality of inner transformation and the place of love, of works, and of the Church. The mature theologian holds the whole: grace alone, received by a faith that works through love, bearing real fruit, within the communion of the Church. And the question still burns in Bengal, where a whole culture is shaped by *karma* and merit, by the long climb of ritual works toward release. To such a people the Gospel of grace is liberating news, that God gives himself freely to those who could never earn him; and against a cheap grace that would leave a man comfortable in his sins, the insistence of Trent on real holiness keeps the news honest. The priest preaches a grace that truly changes lives, neither a legal fiction nor a ladder to be climbed.

Illustration. The first image is the debt paid and the man made a son. Picture a man so deep in debt that he could not pay one paisa of it if he laboured a hundred years, and the moneylenders are at his door. A rich and good man hears of him, comes to his house, and pays the whole debt himself, freely, asking nothing; the poor man brought nothing to it but his empty hands, and that is grace, received by the empty hands of faith. But the rich man does not merely tear up the ledger and walk away, leaving the poor man as he was. He takes him into his own house, seats him at his table, gives him work and a name, and makes him a son; and now the man truly labours in the household, not to buy back what was freely given, for that can never be bought, but out of love, as a real son who has been made new. The Reformers feared that such a household would soon imagine it had earned its place; Trent insisted that the man is not only pardoned but truly made a son and given a new life to live. Both are right, and the whole truth is that he is freely redeemed and really remade.

The second image is the wild branch grafted into the living tree, which Saint Paul himself used (Romans 11). A wild branch, cut off and lying on the ground, is dead and barren and can do nothing for itself. The gardener takes that dead branch and grafts it into a living, cultivated tree, and the branch contributes nothing to its own grafting; that is pure grace. But once it is grafted in, the branch is not merely tied on for show while it stays dead; it truly

draws up the living sap of the tree, and it truly comes alive and truly bears fruit, real fruit that hangs from real wood. Faith is the receiving of the grafting, the being joined to Christ the living tree; and the love and the good works of the Christian are the real fruit that the living sap brings forth. To say the branch saved itself would be folly; to say the grafted branch never comes alive and never bears fruit would be to miss the whole point of grafting.

References. The Manual, page 8, for the Reformation and Trent. The Council of Trent, *Decree on Justification* (1547), for justification as grace truly renewing the inner person, faith working through love, the cooperation of the justified, and merit as the gift of God. Romans 1:17, with Habakkuk 2:4, for the righteous living by faith; James 2:14 to 26 for faith apart from works being dead; Galatians 5:6 for faith working through love; and Romans 11:17 to 24 for the grafted branch, all in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. Martin Luther, for *sola fide* and *simul iustus et peccator*. Augustine against Pelagius, for the priority of grace (cross-reference Lecture 10). The *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification* (Lutheran World Federation and the Catholic Church, 1999), for the healing of the sixteenth-century dispute. The Council of Trent, for the establishment of the seminary system.

Cross-references. The slogan of Scripture alone was answered in Lecture 12, with the Catholic account of Scripture, Tradition, and the teaching office. The question of grace against works reaches back to Augustine and Pelagius in Lecture 10, the grammar of heresy as the seizing of one part. The ecumenical mark comes from Lecture 10, returns at Lecture 16, and looks forward to Orthodox theology in Lecture 29 and to interreligious dialogue in Lecture 33. The very seminary in which the course is taught is a fruit of Trent. The divided Western Church that comes out of this age sets the scene for the modern doubt of Lecture 21. The precept be intelligent asks the student to see why the age asked who saves, and how Trent answered, and how the wound is being healed.

For the professor. Lay down the old polemic entirely, for the manual is at its weakest here, and its anti-Protestant heat betrays its own ecumenical mark. Teach Luther as a man in real anguish over a real question, and Trent as a careful and, on justification, a largely successful answer, and the Joint Declaration of 1999 as a genuine healing the students can rejoice in. Tell them, with a little pride, that their own seminary stands because Trent reformed the formation of priests. Keep the heart of it pastoral: the Gospel of grace is the best news a tired, merit-weary people can hear, and Trent keeps that grace from being made cheap. Reading: the Manual, page 8; a short reading on justification, either the Decree of Trent or the Joint Declaration. Reflection prompt: "What the free grace of God, which I can never earn, means for the way I will hear confessions one day, is..."

LECTURE 21: How do we believe in a doubting world? (The modern age)

The opening problem. For most of human history the great religious question was, which religion is true, because nearly everyone believed in God and the only dispute was about how to name and serve him. Then, in the modern age, from the Enlightenment onward, a

new and far harder question arose, and it is the question your students breathe every day. Not which God, but whether there is any God at all, and whether a thinking, educated, scientific person can still honestly believe. Reason, which Aquinas had wedded to faith, declared first its independence and then its hostility. Science explained more and more of the world with no mention of God. The Bible was laid on the dissecting table of history. And faith was pushed quietly to the edges of life, allowed to survive only as a private feeling with no claim on the public truth. So the question of the modern age stands up, and it is not an enemy at the gate but a doubt in the heart: how do we believe at all, honestly, in a world that doubts? Pose it as their own question, for they live inside it.

The teaching content. The shape of the crisis. Trace the doubt so the students can see it whole. The Enlightenment of the eighteenth century enthroned human reason as autonomous and suspicious of all revelation and authority, in the spirit of the command, dare to think for yourself; and from this grew first Deism, a distant clockmaker God who winds up the world and goes away, and then open atheism. Science, in the hands of Newton and later Darwin, explained the workings of the world by natural law, and the God who had been invoked to fill the gaps in our knowledge seemed to shrink as the gaps closed. There came what one writer has called the masters of suspicion: Feuerbach, who said that God is only the projection of our own wishes onto the sky; Marx, who called religion the opium of the people; Nietzsche, who announced that God is dead; and Freud, who treated religion as an illusion of the unconscious. After them, faith had to answer a question it had never quite faced before, not is your doctrine correct, but is your God real at all, or only a human wish dressed up as heaven. And the Scriptures themselves were now studied like any other ancient text, by the historical-critical method, in the long quest for the Jesus of history; this biblical criticism was a real gain, giving the Church tools she still uses, and it was also a real shock to a simple and untested faith.

The Church responds, and the pattern in the response. Watch the pattern, for that is the precept be intelligent. The first response was defence and retrenchment. The First Vatican Council, in 1869 and 1870, reaffirmed against the doubters that God can be known with certainty by the light of reason from the things he has made (*Dei Filius*, and recall Lecture 3 and Lecture 15), and it defined the infallibility of the Pope; the Syllabus of Errors condemned the spirit of the age in a list; and under Pius X the movement called Modernism was condemned and rooted out. This was a Church with the drawbridge up. The second response was the recovery of the medieval masters: Leo XIII, in *Aeterni Patris* of 1879, called for the return to Thomas Aquinas, and the neo-Scholastic theology that followed gave the Church rigour and clarity, and it is the very method of the manual your students learn to read with a searching eye. Its strength was order; its weakness, often, was dryness, a theology cut off from Scripture, from history, and from the living experience of the faithful, which is the very thing the next age would set out to mend.

The deeper and more fruitful response. The most fruitful response was neither to fight reason nor to retreat behind a fortress, but to go deeper than the doubt, down to the human person, to existence itself, to mystery. Here stands the figure of your reading, Gabriel Marcel, and the one distinction every catechist should own: the difference between a problem and a mystery. A problem is something that lies outside me, that I can stand back

from, hold at arm's length, and solve, like a sum in arithmetic or a stalled engine; once solved, it is finished, and I am unchanged. A mystery is something in which I am myself caught up, which I cannot stand outside of, because I am part of the very question, like love, like the evil in my own heart, like my own death, like God. The deep error of the modern doubt was to treat God and faith as problems to be solved or disproved by a detached and tidy reason, when they are mysteries into which the whole person must enter. You do not solve your own mother the way you solve a crossword; you do not prove the love of your friend the way you prove a theorem; and you do not meet God as the conclusion of an argument but as the One in whom you live. This single distinction reframes the entire quarrel of faith and reason, and it sets free the believer who had been told that, because he cannot prove God like a sum, he may not honestly believe at all. Alongside Marcel came the recovery of the sources, the *ressourcement* of theologians such as de Lubac, Congar, and Daniélou, who went back behind the dry manuals to Scripture and the Fathers, and the turn to the human subject of Karl Rahner from Lecture 8; and these currents would feed the Council of the next lecture.

The Church reads the modern world with compassion. Your reading from *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 1 to 4, shows the turn that was coming: the Church no longer addressing the modern world only with condemnation, but standing in solidarity with it, taking the joys and the hopes, the griefs and the anxieties of the people of this age as her own (*Gaudium et Spes* 1), reading the signs of the times (*Gaudium et Spes* 4), and meeting modern doubt, atheism, and anguish not with an anathema but with compassion and dialogue. This is the move from the fortress to the open road, and it carries us straight to Lecture 22.

The payoff for Bengal and the digital age. Make this lecture land at home, because it is the students' own air. Their people, and above all the young, live inside this doubt: science in the schoolroom, a secular and mocking media, the masters of suspicion repeated as common sense, religion treated as superstition or as private sentiment. The priest must learn to preach a faith that is honest before doubt and unafraid of science, a faith that goes deeper than the problem-solving mind to the mystery in which the whole person stands. The distinction of Marcel is a tool he will use every week: to the young man who says he cannot prove God and so will not believe, the priest can answer that God is not a problem he failed to solve, but a mystery he is invited to enter, the way he has already entered, without proof and without regret, the mystery of being loved.

Illustration. The first image is the locked box and the unlit room. A problem is like a locked box sitting on the table in front of you: you can pick it up, turn it over in your hands, study it from every side, find the key, open it, and be finished with it, and you walk away unchanged. A mystery is not like that at all. A mystery is like a great unlit room in which you are already standing, in the dark. You cannot pick the room up and turn it over, because you are inside it; you cannot solve it from the outside, because there is no outside for you to stand on. You can only move within it, let your eyes slowly grow used to the dark, and begin to walk by a light you did not switch on. God is not the box on the table; God is the room you are standing in. The modern doubter tries to set God on the table like a box, and, failing to prise him open, declares the box empty; the believer knows that he has been standing

inside the room all along, and that the darkness is not absence but a light too great for his eyes.

The second image is the telescope that cannot weigh sorrow. Modern science is a magnificent telescope, and it has shown us the how of the heavens in dazzling detail, the burning of the stars, the bending of light, the long slow turning of the galaxies. But a telescope, however vast and however true, cannot tell you why there is a heaven at all, or whether it is loved, any more than a thermometer can be made to weigh sorrow or a ruler to measure justice. The error of the age is to suppose that, because the telescope sees so very far, there can be nothing real that the telescope cannot see. But the question of meaning, the question of why, the question of God, is not a faint and distant star that the telescope simply failed to find; it is a question of another order entirely, as out of reach of the instrument as the weight of grief is out of reach of the thermometer. Science answers a thousand questions of how, and leaves untouched the one question of why, which is the question the human heart cannot stop asking.

References. The Manual, pages 8 to 9, for the modern age. *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 1 to 4, for the Church in solidarity with the modern world and the reading of the signs of the times. Gabriel Marcel, *Being and Having* and *The Mystery of Being*, for the distinction between a problem and a mystery. The First Vatican Council, *Dei Filius* (1870), for the knowledge of God by the light of reason (cross-reference Lecture 3 and Lecture 15). Leo XIII, *Aeterni Patris* (1879), for the recovery of Aquinas. Paul Ricoeur, for the phrase the masters of suspicion, applied to Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud, and Ludwig Feuerbach, for God as projection. For the recovery of the sources, the theologians of the *ressourcement*, Henri de Lubac, Yves Congar, and Jean Daniélou (cross-reference Lecture 14), and Karl Rahner, for the turn to the subject (cross-reference Lecture 8).

Cross-references. The natural knowledge of God by reason comes from Lecture 3 and Lecture 15. The turn to the subject comes from Lecture 8. The loosening of the bond between faith and reason in late nominalism, Lecture 19, bears its bitter fruit here. The neo-Scholastic manual the students read with a searching eye is itself a child of this age. The question whether God is real or only a projection returns in the lecture on whether a machine can do theology, Lecture 30, and in interreligious dialogue, Lecture 33. The distinction between problem and mystery prepares the apophatic and worshipping theology of Lecture 29. *Gaudium et Spes* opens directly onto Lecture 22 and governs the whole of Unit VI. The precept be intelligent asks the student to grasp the pattern of crisis and response.

For the professor. This is the students' own age, so make it personal from the first minute: their people, and especially the young they will one day catechise, live inside this very doubt. Do not present the modern world only as an enemy; the historical study of the Bible and the human sciences are real gifts, and the best Catholic response was never the Syllabus but the turn to the person and to mystery that opened the door to the Council. Put the distinction of Marcel firmly into their hands as a working tool, and have them practise answering, in plain words, the young man who says that he cannot prove God and so will not believe. Reading: the Manual, pages 8 to 9; *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 1 to 4. Reflection

prompt: "When someone tells me that a thinking person cannot believe in God today, the first thing I want to say to him is..."

LECTURE 22: What did the Church wake up to? (Vatican II)

The opening problem. By the early twentieth century the Catholic Church looked, to many both inside and outside her, like a fortress with the drawbridge up. She had been on the defensive since Trent, hardened against the modern world since the First Vatican Council and the rooting out of Modernism, still speaking Latin to a world that had long moved on, and inclined to regard other Christians and other religions with suspicion. Then, in 1959, an old Pope whom everyone had taken for a harmless caretaker, John XXIII, astonished the whole Church by calling a council, not to condemn a heresy or define a dogma, but, as he put it, to open the windows of the house and let in some fresh air. So pose the question of this last lecture of the unit: what did the Church wake up to at the Second Vatican Council? What changed, and, just as importantly, what did not change? For the answer is the Church that your students are about to be ordained to serve.

The teaching content. The setting and the surprise. John XXIII summoned the Second Vatican Council, which sat from 1962 to 1965 and was the largest council in the history of the Church. It was called not to hurl anathemas, and it pronounced none, the first general council in centuries to condemn no one; it was called for *aggiornamento*, a bringing of the Church up to date, and for pastoral renewal, that the one unchanging faith might be presented afresh to the people of a new age. The image John XXIII used has never been bettered: a house too long shut up grows stale and dim, and it is time to open the windows.

The two engines, and the pattern. Show the students the two forces that drove the renewal, for grasping them is the precept be intelligent. The first is *aggiornamento*, the updating: the Church reading the signs of her own time (*Gaudium et Spes* 4), speaking to the modern world in a language it could hear, engaging it rather than fleeing from it. The second, and less noticed, is *ressourcement*, the return to the sources: the renewal came not by inventing something new but by going back behind the dry manuals to the deep and ancient springs, to Scripture, to the Fathers, to the liturgy of the early Church. And here is a turn the students will relish: the very theologians who had been silenced or suspected before the Council, de Lubac, Congar, Daniélou, Rahner, the men of Lecture 14, became its chief architects. So the Council was at once newer and older than the manual: newer in facing the modern world without fear, and older in drinking again from the most ancient wells of the faith.

What the Church woke up to: the great Constitutions. The fruit of the Council can be seen in its four great Constitutions, and you should name what each one awakened. On the Church, *Lumen Gentium* taught that the Church is first of all the People of God, a pilgrim people on the way, before she is a hierarchy or an institution; that every baptised person, and not only the priest and the religious, is called to the heights of holiness, the universal call to holiness; and that the bishops together, in communion with the Pope, share the care of the whole Church, which is collegiality. On divine revelation, *Dei Verbum* re-mapped the

sources, as the students learned fully in Lecture 16: one wellspring, two streams, one table, the open Bible, Scripture the soul of theology. On the liturgy, *Sacrosanctum Concilium* reformed the worship of the Church, opened the door to the mother tongue, called for the full and active participation of all the people, and named the liturgy the source and the summit of the whole life of the Church; the Mass that your students will one day celebrate in Bengali and in Hindi is a direct fruit of this Constitution. And on the Church in the modern world, *Gaudium et Spes* set the Church in solidarity with the human family, taking up its joys and its griefs (*Gaudium et Spes* 1), reading the signs of the times, and speaking to culture, work, marriage, peace, and even atheism, not from behind a wall but as a companion on the road.

And the renewed understanding of those outside. Add what the Council woke up to about those beyond the visible borders of the Church. In *Nostra Aetate* she declared that she rejects nothing of what is true and holy in the other religions, that she regards the Muslims with esteem and holds in reverence her bond with the Jewish people. In *Dignitatis Humanae* she taught the right of every person to religious freedom. And in *Unitatis Redintegratio* she turned toward the other Christians no longer as enemies but as separated brothers and sisters, and committed herself to the long work of Christian reunion. This drive toward reunion and dialogue is the open door through which the Church of Bengal now lives among her Hindu, Muslim, and Buddhist neighbours.

What did not change. Guard the students carefully here, for this is where both the frightened and the careless go wrong. The Gospel did not change; the Creed did not change; the deposit of faith did not change. John XXIII said it best in his opening address: the substance of the ancient faith is one thing, and the way in which it is expressed is another. *Aggiornamento* is the development of the one faith, in the sense of Lecture 13 and of Newman, a fresh expression of the same faith, and not its replacement. The traditionalist fear, that the Council changed the faith, and the careless temptation, that after the Council anything at all is permitted, both misread what happened. As Benedict XVI taught, the Council must be read by a hermeneutic of reform in continuity and not by a hermeneutic of rupture: it was deeper fidelity and fresher expression at once, the same faith, awake.

The payoff, and the bridge to the present. Tell the students plainly that they are children of this Council. The Mass in the mother tongue, the open Bible in the hands of the people from Lecture 16, the dialogue with the neighbours of other faiths from Lecture 33, the care for the poor from Lecture 15 and Lecture 26, the lay leadership of the Basic Christian Communities, the synodality of Lecture 31, all of it is the country that the Council opened and the seminary now serves. And the Council does not end the story; it hands it on. Vatican II read the signs of its own time; Unit VI will ask the students to read the signs of theirs, the questions of artificial intelligence, of synodality, of the wounded earth, of a plural world. So this lecture is the hinge between the history that is behind them and the responsible theologian they are being formed to become.

Illustration. The first image is the fortress-city whose gates are opened at dawn. Picture an old walled city that, since the wars of long ago, had kept every gate bolted day and night, for fear of the enemy outside; and over the years, behind those bolted gates, the air had grown

stale, the markets had emptied, no traveller brought news, and even the morning light could barely reach the streets. A new captain came, who trusted the strength of the ancient walls, and he gave two commands. He opened the gates at dawn, so that the light could come in, and the merchants, and the messengers with news of the wide world; that is *aggiornamento*. And he broke the seals on the old archives deep within the citadel, where the founding charters of the city had been shut away and forgotten, so that the people could read again the very words on which their city was built; that is *ressourcement*. The city was not surrendered, and not one stone of its true walls was pulled down; it was opened, and it remembered itself, and it began to live again. So did the Church at the Council, opening her gates to the world and unsealing her most ancient charters at once.

The second image is the ancestral song sung at last in the children's own tongue. A family had a beloved ancestral song, sung at every wedding and every feast for many generations; but it had been sung so long in an old language that no living child any longer understood it, so that the young only mouthed the sounds by rote, and the meaning had slipped away like water through open fingers. Then the elders did a daring and a tender thing: they kept the very same song, every note and every line of it, and they set it in the tongue the children actually spoke. And the young, hearing for the first time what they had been singing all their lives, sang it now with tears and with understanding. The song was not changed; only its language was renewed, and the old meaning came alive in new mouths. That is what the Council did with the worship and the faith of the Church: it did not write a new song, it let the children sing the ancient one in their own tongue, so that the substance, which is one, came alive in an expression, which is new.

References. The Manual, pages 8 to 9, for the Second Vatican Council. *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 4 to 10, for the reading of the signs of the times and the Church in the modern world, with *Gaudium et Spes* 1 (cross-reference Lecture 21). The four Constitutions of the Council: *Lumen Gentium*, on the Church as the People of God, the universal call to holiness, and collegiality; *Dei Verbum*, on divine revelation (cross-reference Lecture 16); *Sacrosanctum Concilium*, on the liturgy, the mother tongue, and full and active participation; and *Gaudium et Spes*, on the Church in the modern world. *Nostra Aetate*, on the other religions; *Unitatis Redintegratio*, on Christian reunion and the separated brethren; and *Dignitatis Humanae*, on religious freedom. John XXIII, the opening address *Gaudet Mater Ecclesia* (1962), for *aggiornamento*, the opened windows, and the substance of the faith being one thing and its expression another. For the recovery of the sources, the *ressourcement* of de Lubac, Congar, Daniélou, and Rahner. Benedict XVI, the address to the Roman Curia (2005), on the hermeneutic of reform in continuity.

Cross-references. This lecture gathers the re-mapping of the sources from Lecture 16, the People of God and the *sensus fidelium* from Lecture 14, the ecumenical mark from Lecture 10 and Lecture 20, and the care for the poor from Lecture 15. The architects of the Council were the once-suspected theologians of Lecture 14. The teaching that the substance of the faith is one and its expression another is the development that preserves identity from Lecture 13. The Council that reads the signs of its own time opens directly onto Unit VI, where the responsible theologian reads the signs of ours: artificial intelligence in Lecture 30, synodality in Lecture 31, ecology in Lecture 32, and dialogue and pluralism in Lecture

33. The vernacular liturgy grounds the mother-tongue Mass the students will celebrate. The precept be intelligent completes its work here: the student now grasps the whole movement of the history as one chain of questions, arriving at the Council that made the Church he serves.

For the professor. This lecture is the hinge between the history and the present, so teach it as an awakening and not as a rupture. Give the students John XXIII opening the windows, and then insist, with Benedict XVI, that the Council was reform in continuity, the same faith made new in its expression and not a new faith. Make it personal: every student before you is a child of this Council, from the Mass in his mother tongue to the open Bible to the friendship he will keep with his Hindu and Muslim neighbours. End by pointing forward, that the Council read the signs of its time, and that Unit VI will ask each of them to read the signs of his own. Reading: the Manual, pages 8 to 9; *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 4 to 10. Reflection prompt: "One gift of the Second Vatican Council that I had taken for granted, and now see as a gift, is..."

CLOSING THE UNIT, AND THE BRIDGE TO UNIT V

By the end of Unit IV the students should be able to read the history of theology not as a graveyard of dates and councils but as a chain of living questions, each age answering its own crisis with the one unchanging Gospel. The Patristic age asked who Jesus is, and answered at Nicaea and at Chalcedon, against every heresy that tore at the person of Christ. The Scholastic age asked whether faith and reason can live together, and answered in the great synthesis of Aquinas, who baptised the reason of Aristotle and set it to serve the faith. The Reformation and the Council of Trent asked who saves and how, the question of grace, and the wound that question opened is, in our own day, being healed. The modern age asked the hardest question of all, how to believe at all in a world that doubts, and learned at its best to go deeper than the problem to the mystery. And the Second Vatican Council asked what the Church must wake up to, and answered with *aggiornamento* and *ressourcement*, opening her gates to the world and unsealing her most ancient sources at once. Above all, the students have practised the second precept of Lonergan, be intelligent: to seek not the date but the insight, to ask of every age what question it was struggling with and what truth it was guarding. And they have seen that they too live in an age with its own question, so that this whole history has been their apprenticeship.

The natural next question follows at once. Given all that they have received from the sources, and all that they have learned from the history, how is theology actually done? By what method does a theologian move from Scripture, Tradition, and the questions of his own people to a faithful and living word for today? That is the work of Unit V, the methods of theology, which is the heart of the whole course, Lectures 23 to 29, where the third precept, be reasonable, begins to govern, and where the six models of Stephen Bevans will show that liberation theology, Dalit theology, Indian theology, and feminist theology are not a confusion to be feared but many models doing one work, with Orthodox theology closing

the unit on its knees. The next installment of these notes will cover Unit V, in the same form.

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